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Hitting In Two Leagues

LAKE WALES, FLA., March 28—Gordon Windhorn, the outfielder who once again is trying to make a home for himself with the Virginians, has the look of an All-American boy. He comes equipped with a big smile, broad shoulders, wavy reddish-blond hair and he runs with his toes pointed upward.

In the American Association, which also is a triple-A league, Windhorn always was hit the way All-American boys are supposed to. In the International League, he's always been something of an All-American out.

Windhorn hit an undistinguished .249 for the Vees in '57 and the next year moved to Denver where he captured the American Association batting championship with a .328 mark.

Last year, Windhorn was a Vee for two unhappy weeks in May. Unproud possessor of a .179 batting average and one RBI, he was dispatched again to Denver where he hit .312 which, if not a championship pace, is a highly respectable one.

Windhorn's heroics at Denver and lack of same for the Vees has led to some unkind remarks that perhaps the AA is not quite as strong as the IL.

Is there some suspicion that Windhorn has trouble combating a curve? There is. Obviously, then, the altitude makes the curve practically unknown at Denver. Elsewhere, 'A' pitchers, equally as obviously, throw what may best be described as bargain basement type curves.

Not surprisingly, Windhorn gives the back of his hand to suggestions there may be a difference between the two leagues. He does concede, when pushed hard enough, that, as a class, IL pitchers may be a mite smarter than their AA opposites. But he adds heatedly, not that much smarter.

SO, IF you buy Windhorn's story that the difference in pitching in the two leagues isn't big enough to be measured by the naked eye. . . How do you explain Windhorn's record?

Windhorn has one ready explanation. It has nothing to do with curves, altitude or hitting. At Denver, he says, he was much admired by his managers—Andy Cohen in '57 and Stan Hack last year. At Richmond, he says, he never heard too many cheers from the bench . . . and never got too much of an opportunity to play every day.

"Any hitter has got to play regularly to hit well," Windhorn says. "And I'm a slow starter. I told Hack that last year. I was hitting under .200 after my first month at Denver, but Hack stayed with me. . ."

When Windhorn talks about lack of cheers and opportunity with the Vees, he may not be giving a completely accurate sum-up of the situation. In '57 when the Vees might have won the pennant had they had one strong right-handed hitter, Ed Lopat gave Windhorn the opportunity in 127 games he was the man so desperately needed.

To be sure last year there was a personality conflict between Windhorn and Steve Souchock. But even so, Souchock, who was in desperate need of right or left-handed hitting, did give Windhorn reasonable opportunity to prove he had not won the AA batting championship through liberal use of mirrors.

Looking back at last year's Vee debacle, Windhorn maintains there were extenuating circumstances. "I had sat on the bench with the Yankees for a month and. . ." This leads to another battle of sorts with management.

LAST SPRING, as you may recall, Windhorn, although listed on the Vee roster, trained with the Yankees. It was not because, as Casey Stengel pointed out several times, because anyone believed Windhorn could make the Yankees . . . but because of a rather indignant letter Windhorn had written Stengel in which he pointed out that the AA batting championship should be reference enough for an invitation to a major league spring training camp.

Windhorn wound up winning the watch New York writers annually vote to the best looking rookie in the Yankee camp . . . partly because of his hitting in exhibition games . . . and partly, to be blunt, by default.

Windhorn was with the Yankees for the start of the American League season, sat for a month and never came to bat. "I can't blame Stengel," he says. "The Yankees were losing and he had to play his established players. Suppose he had used rookies and lost. . . He would have been second-guessed."

However, the watch he won last spring is now one of Windhorn's more treasured possessions. . . "Another example," he says, "of a difference of opinion between the press and a manager."

BECAUSE OF his past, Windhorn admittedly faces an uphill-all-the-way fight to make the Vees. Windhorn considers this unfortunate, for the Vees as well as himself since he wants to play in Richmond because he's about to open a bowling alley in Danville, his wife's home town.

Windhorn figures this year the Vee customers would see a new model. . . "because I've learned to hit the curve." This is a secret which if bottled could make the discoverer a million, but Windhorn says it was relatively easy.

"I just began figuring I wasn't going to overpower those outside pitches," he says. "So I began slapping at them." Slapping or not, Windhorn did manage to hit 15 homers at Denver last season to tie a career high.

His past IL curve difficulties isn't the only rap against Windhorn. His arm and defensive play are considered weak. "I'm not that bad defensively," Windhorn says, "and how many runners does a leftfielder throw out in a season?"

Richmond customers aren't likely to discover how many leftfielder Windhorn can throw out in '60. One guess is that to see Parker Field this season, Windhorn will have to hit phenomenally—not sensationally but phenomenally—in the remaining exhibitions.